Pronomi soggetto e il Lei

Subject pronouns and formal “you”. The words for I, you, he, she, we, they, when Italians actually say them, and the polite “you” (Lei) you use with strangers.

The idea

Italian has subject pronouns (**io, tu, lui, lei, noi, voi, loro**), but usually leaves them out: the verb ending already tells you who. You say them for contrast, for emphasis, or when they stand alone. Italian also has two ways to say “you” to one person: **tu** for friends, family and children, and **Lei** for strangers, shop staff, older people and at work.

When to use it

Normally left out
The ending of the verb is enough. Adding the pronoun every time sounds heavy.

Parlo inglese e un po' di italiano. · I speak English and a bit of Italian.

Contrast
When two people do different things, say both pronouns.

Io lavoro dalle otto, e tu dormi fino a mezzogiorno? · I've been working since eight, and you sleep till noon?

Alone or after anche / neanche
When there is no verb, or after **anche** (too) and **neanche** (neither), the pronoun is required.

Chi ha finito il caffè? — Lui, come sempre. · Who finished the coffee? — Him, as usual.

tu: informal you
For friends, family, children, and people your age in relaxed settings.

Sara, vieni anche tu stasera? · Sara, are you coming tonight too?

Lei: formal you
For people you don't know, at work, in shops and offices. **Lei** takes the same verb form as lui and lei.

Scusi, Lei è il dottor Ferri? · Excuse me, are you Dr Ferri?

voi: you, plural
For any group of two or more people, formal or informal.

Ragazzi, voi cosa prendete? · Guys, what are you having?

How it works

Subject pronouns go before the verb. **Lei** (formal you) uses the same verb form as lui / lei (*Lei parla*), and is often written with a capital L in emails and letters.

Subject pronouns

io	I (small i, except at the start of a sentence)
tu	you: one person, informal
lui / lei	he / she
Lei	you: one person, formal (verb as for lui / lei)
noi	we
voi	you: more than one person
loro	they

tu, Lei or voi?

tu	friends, family, children, classmates, young people among themselves
Lei	strangers, shop and office staff, doctors, older people, colleagues until they suggest tu
voi	any group, formal or informal

- For things, Italians simply drop the pronoun: *È rotto.* = It's broken. (*esso, essa* exist but belong to formal writing.)
- **dare del tu / del Lei** = to use tu / Lei with someone. To switch, people ask: *Possiamo darci del tu?*
- With Lei, adjectives agree with the real person: *Signor Bassi, Lei è stanco? Signora, Lei è stanca?*
- **anche io** is often written **anch'io**. Both are correct.

Common mistakes

✗ ~~Signora, tu vuoi un caffè?~~
✓ Signora, (Lei) vuole un caffè?
Signora calls for **Lei**, and Lei takes the third-person verb: vuole, not vuoi.

✗ ~~Io sono Ruth, io sono di Leeds e io lavoro in un ospedale.~~
✓ Sono Ruth, sono di Leeds e lavoro in un ospedale.
The endings already say who. Repeating io sounds like you're insisting on it.

✗ ~~Vado al mare. — Anche me!~~
✓ Vado al mare. — Anch'io!
You are the subject (I'm going too), so use **io**. *Me* is for after prepositions: *con me, per me*.

✗ ~~Professore, Lei parli inglese?~~
✓ Professore, Lei parla inglese?
Lei always takes the lui / lei form of the verb.

Exercises

1. Mia sorella fa la veterinaria a Cuneo, _____ invece studio ancora. (pronoun)

2. Abbiamo sentito tutti. E _____, signor Amato, cosa ne pensa? (pronoun · formal)
3. Scusi, signore, _____ un minuto per un sondaggio? (avere · Lei)
4. Signora Gatti, _____ un'altra fetta di torta? (volere · Lei)
5. Sabato vado a Trieste. — Anche _____! Andiamo insieme? (pronoun · I)
6. Ragazzi, _____ cosa prendete? Io un gelato al pistacchio. (pronoun)
7. Elena e Davide abitano a Matera, ma _____ non sono di lì. (pronoun)
8. Io cucino tutti i giorni. Mio fratello no: _____ ordina sempre la pizza. (pronoun)
9. Dottor Neri, Lei _____ di turno anche stanotte? (essere · Lei)
10. Signora Lombardi, Lei è _____ oggi? Si sieda un momento. (stanco)
11. At a bakery in Lecce, to a shop assistant you've never met:
    a. Scusa, hai il pane integrale?
    b. Scusi, ha il pane integrale?
    c. Scusate, hai il pane integrale?
12. Your new flatmate in Bologna (25, very relaxed) asks where you're from. You ask back:
    a. E tu, di dove sei?
    b. E Lei, di dov'è?
    c. E voi, di dove siete?
13. Which sounds natural, not emphatic?
    a. Io mi chiamo Ruth e io abito a Cagliari.
    b. Mi chiamo Ruth e abito a Cagliari.
    c. Mi chiamo Ruth e io abito a Cagliari.

Answers

1. **io** · A contrast between two people: say the pronoun. Studio tells you it's io.
2. **lei** · Pensa + signor Amato: formal you, Lei, stressed here because you turn to him.
3. **ha** · Scusi is formal, so the verb is the Lei form: ha (like lui / lei).
4. **vuole** · Lei takes the third-person form: vuole, not vuoi.
5. **io** · After anche the pronoun is required. Written together it's anch'io.
6. **voi** · Prendete is the voi form: more than one person.
7. **loro** · Sono here means they are: loro, stressed for contrast with the town.
8. **lui** · Contrast between me and my brother: lui.
9. **è** · Lei è, exactly like lui è. Don't forget the accent.
10. **stanca** · Lei is grammatically third person, but the adjective agrees with the real person: a woman, so stanca.

11. **Scusi, ha il pane integrale?** · A stranger serving you: Lei. Scusi and ha are both Lei forms.
12. **E tu, di dove sei?** · Young people among themselves use tu straight away.
13. **Mi chiamo Ruth e abito a Cagliari.** · No contrast, no emphasis: leave io out.